

Georgia Geopolitical Positioning

Georgia, South Caucasus

SIGNAL

Georgia is pursuing transactional relationships with the US, Russia, and the EU simultaneously while committing to none.

FRACTURE

Georgian Dream's regime survival doctrine – presenting as pro-Western while avoiding substantive democratic reforms – is straining relations with the EU even as the US engages pragmatically.

The US reset will deepen over the next 18 months, giving Georgian Dream enough cover to further delay EU accession reforms without triggering a definitive break with Washington.

75%

PROBABILITY

Target: December 2027

Confidence: Medium

ANALYSIS**POLITICAL**

The dominant political dynamic remains Georgian Dream's regime survival doctrine – and the developments since the last report reinforce rather than disrupt it. Kobakhidze's annual report is a carefully constructed document designed to present GD as simultaneously pro-Western (850 Ukraine resolutions, 380 statements), pro-US (reset agenda), and pro-EU (integration commitments) – while doing none of the substantive democratic reforms that would make any of these claims credible to Western institutions.

The US reset is the most significant active file. The Trump administration's willingness to engage is real, driven by Middle Corridor interest and transactional diplomacy. But the US Embassy's statement – emphasizing democratic functioning and opposition engagement – reveals that Washington is not simply rubber-stamping GD's approach. The reset is conditional and cautious, not a blank check.

The Ukraine reset is more ambiguous. Zelenskyy's engagement with Kobakhidze is striking given that the Georgian PM remains under Ukrainian sanctions. This suggests Kyiv may be prioritizing regional stability and corridor access over democratic conditionality – a pragmatic calculation, but one that confuses and demoralizes Georgia's pro-European opposition.

The German Ambassador row is a leading indicator. GD's aggressive pushback against Fischer (calling his remarks "xenophobic") is a deliberate escalation against the EU's most influential member state. It signals GD's calculation that the Trump reset insulates

it from European pressure. This is a risky bet – Germany remains Georgia's largest EU trade partner and a key voice in accession decisions.

The domestic political trajectory is frozen. The October 4 coup case plea deals give GD a judicial narrative of legitimacy. The opposition remains fragmented and boycotting parliament. The protests continue but have not reached a scale that threatens GD's grip. The next parliamentary elections (October 2028) are the likely inflection point.

ECONOMIC

Georgia's economy continues to perform well (EBRD 6% forecast), driven by transit, logistics, ICT, and tourism. The Georgia-Azerbaijan energy agreements are economically rational in the short term – securing gas supply and rail connectivity – but strategically concerning. The shift toward Russian gas dependence is a quiet but significant vulnerability. If Western sanctions on Russia tighten further, Georgia could face energy supply complications or be forced into costly diversification.

The Middle Corridor remains Georgia's strongest economic card. The Baku-Tbilisi-Kars railway restoration and the new section being made operational reinforce Georgia's irreplaceable geographic position. Chinese-financed infrastructure projects at Georgian deep-sea ports remain a flashpoint – they would increase capacity but deepen Chinese economic influence in a sector the US views through a strategic competition lens.

The Swissôtel Kobuleti project and similar investments signal that FDI continues despite political headwinds. But this investment is concentrated in tourism and real estate – sectors that are vulnerable to geopolitical shocks and don't build the industrial base Georgia needs for EU accession.

MILITARY

No significant changes since the last report. Russia's occupation of 20% of Georgian territory remains the defining military fact. GD continues its deliberate demilitarization of the Western alignment – no NATO exercises, no military cooperation with Ukraine, no reintegration rhetoric. Russian forces in Abkhazia and South Ossetia continue creeping borderization. The military balance heavily favors Russia, and GD's caution is driven by the fear of becoming "a second Ukraine" – a fear that Russia's continued presence in Georgian territory reinforces regardless of whether Moscow has the intent or capacity to act.

The US military relationship remains minimal. The Trump reset has not included any visible security component. This is a gap – if the reset deepens, military-to-military engagement would be the most concrete signal of a genuine strategic shift.

TECHNOLOGICAL

Georgia's ICT sector continues to grow, but the technological dimension of Georgia's geopolitical positioning is increasingly a US-China competition zone. Chinese tech investment (potential 5G, surveillance systems, port digital infrastructure) is a concern for Washington. The Trump administration is likely to push back on Chinese tech

penetration as part of any deeper engagement. Georgia's tech sector thus faces a forced-choice dynamic that mirrors the broader geopolitical drift.

WATCH INDICATORS

- US-Georgia diplomatic engagement depth (visits, statements, agreements)
- EU accession process milestones or setbacks
- Russian gas supply negotiations and pricing
- Georgian Dream rhetoric and domestic legal actions toward opposition
- Chinese infrastructure investment in Georgian transport/logistics
- October 2028 election timeline developments

PROBABILITY TRIGGERS

THING	DIRECTION
US announces new security or economic commitment to Georgia	Down
EU grants Georgia candidate status or advances accession talks	Down
US-Georgia relations cool or reset stalls	Up
GD accelerates democratic reforms to preempt EU pressure	Down
Russia formalizes a new security or economic arrangement with Georgia	Up
US publicly criticizes GD's democratic backsliding	Up

KEY SOURCES

1. JAMnews: Georgia PM's Annual Report
2. Commonsplace.eu: Georgia-Azerbaijan Agreements
3. Imedi News: PM Welcomes New US Administration Approach
4. Commonsplace.eu: German Ambassador Row
5. US Embassy in Georgia: Democracy Statement
6. Imedi News: EBRD Upgrades Growth Forecast
7. Imedi News: October 4 Coup Case Plea Deals

